

PHONOTRIENE

R. Lima.

ABSTRACT

My research explores the intersection of craft, sound, and ritual as a methodology for healing and social cohesion. Focusing on the creation of ceramic sounding entities, the project investigates how clay instruments can act as vessels for spiritual connection and psychological repair.

Drawing upon a hybrid background that spans Caribbean and Iberian cultures, I examine syncretic spiritual traditions - specifically the Venezuelan cult of María Lionza and Portuguese folk ceramics - to understand how ritual objects embody agency.

Through a practice-based inquiry, I analyze the process of crafting aerophones (wind instruments) and idiophones (rattles/maracas) designed to facilitate a communal soundscape of healing. By integrating Jungian music psychotherapy with anthropological perspectives on Lowland South American sonic rituals, the study posits that sound bypasses rational defense mechanisms, allowing participants to access a state of liminality and collective vulnerability.

The culmination of this research is a ritual performance entitled “PHONOTRIENE” which seeks to repatriate Nordic spiritual energies through ceramic sounding objects, transforming the exhibition space into a site for acoustic alchemy and shared transformation.

Keywords: Craft, Ceramics, Sound Art, Ritual Performance, Radical Syncretism, Sound Healing, Jungian Psychology, María Lionza, Popular religiosity, Figurines, Ritual objects, Visual Cosmologies

TABLE OF CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION.....4.

THE JOURNEY: BETWEEN LANDS AND BELIEFS.....5.
-Hybrid Cosmologies
-Ritual healing: Limpia de Huevo
-The Commandment

SYNCRETIC REALITIES.....7.
-Rosa's Universe
-Rites of a Hybrid

THE PROCESS: CRAFTING THE SPIRITSCAPE.....9.

BETWEEN MATERIAL AND ETHEREAL.....11.
-The Sonic Bridge
-The Physics of the "Uncanny" Voice
-Entrainment of the body
-Healing Tunes: The Archetype of Home

INTERRITUALITY AND AGENCY.....14.

-Spiritual Essence
-Viking Repatriation
-Ritual and Material Mimesis

CONCLUSION.....17.

BIBLIOGRAPHY.....18.

Note:
to fully experience the development of the work, I recoment for this paper to be read on a digital device with internet conection. This will allow you to access the youtube links I refer to throughout the text .

INTRODUCTION

PHONOTRIENE [1] is crafted and sounding medicine. It acts at the material, psychological, and spiritual level, the holy trinity of human existence. In them I strive to find the basis to appease my longings, to materialize personal experiences and to connect me to the 'other' - not as a separate entity but as a continuation of myself.

What I offer in this paper is not a definitive interpretation, but an attempt to express within an institutional framework the knowledge and lived experiences I carry. My ideas are embodied more clearly in the objects I make than in the words I write. There is something in the act of making that feels more honest, more clear, more eloquent than the rigid and limited realm of words and concepts. My hands often express effortlessly what I struggle to put into spoken or written language. They are better at illustrating the layered themes, the contradictions, the spiritual essence that runs through my work and myself.

That's part of my discomfort: how can I translate into text what comes so naturally through clay, form, and ritual gesture? How do I convey, in this format, something that is inherently embodied, intuitive, and mythic?

This paper is, therefore, an offering, an exploration of how in rituals we can find a healing act, a mechanism for social cohesion, and a tool for liberation, both in traditional spiritual contexts and within contemporary art-making practices. In this context, I am invested in how sound become channel for spiritual connection, how it acts as material, and how it shows something essential about the human condition: its multiplicity, its hybridity, and its deep need for meaning. I draw from a wide spectrum of influences: Venezuelan Spiritism, Jungian music psychotherapy, and Iberian folk traditions. What brings them together isn't one single truth, but a shared focus on ritual, symbolism, and the power of personal reinvention. These practices allow for complexity. They welcome contradictions. They offer a space to hold both personal myth and collective memory. This is not a search for mastery, but for resonance.

In this journey I will inquire in how do syncretic, performative, and ritual practices relate to broader themes of hybridity, belonging, and communion and where does craft, more specifically ceramic figurines, stand in these negotiations?

1. Phonotriene (n.) - phono- (prefix): From Gk. phōnē "voice, sound," from PIE root *bha- (2) "to speak, tell, say." + triene (suffix): A dual-layered morpheme:
-Theological/Philosophical: From Lat. trinitas "number three, a triad," from trinus "threefold." Refers to the tripartite "holy trinity of human existence":
-Pharmacological: Borrowed from organic chemistry nomenclature (-triene), indicating a molecule with three double bonds (e.g., leukotriene

Hybrid Cosmologies

My relationship with the divine has always been filtered through my mother. Her search for meaning and transcendence led us through various religious and esoteric traditions, each offering a temporary structure. In this project, I draw upon not only the occasions I have experienced distinct belief systems but also the intersection between the craftscapes that make up my hybrid identity.

As a someone raised between Venezuela, Spain, and Portugal, and living in Scandinavia since 2020, I constantly navigate tensions between rootedness and transition, alienation and belonging.

I embody tensions between interwoven cultures and constant transformations in how I perceive myself and my position in society. Through this lens, I explore how syncretic expressions offer mechanisms to dissolve rigid boundaries, both physical and conceptual, by highlighting the resilience of marginalized belief systems and their role in cultural preservation and reinvention.

I will explore the relation between ceramic figurines to ritual, healing and community cohesion. This serves as a framework to construct a new reality; a dimension built upon personal mythologies—taking from personal experiences with my "hero's journey" through different belief landscapes. From my participation in Roman Catholic rituals and evangelical cults to eastern spiritual practices, folk mysticism, and other personal spiritual experiences.

The aim is to craft a ritual that revolves around of ceramic figures and that invites participants to engage with the resonating qualities of the pieces, to become part of the ritual by contributing to the creation of a responsive soundscape/spiritscape. By welcoming the participants/devotees into the work, I expect to invoke experiences of the sacred, of the charming uncanny, and of the universality of human experience. I seek to spark reflections about the role of rituals in a secular contemporary society. But above all, I want to create a platform to investigate and share through sounding ceramic figures a communal experience of sound healing.



IMAGE 1.

R.Lima, 2025. 41x45x17 cm.

Ceramic sounding mask. Glazed Stoneware - object from the PHONOTRIENE series

Ritual healing - Limpia de huevo [2.]

In 2015, after years of debilitating coughs and respiratory symptoms, I faced a dilemma. I had undergone examinations and treatments with numerous specialists, all of whom concluded that the several exams performed didn't show any issue at all. Tired of my quality of life being affected, I approached my mother, who mentioned Eloisa, a long-time family friend and healer from Mexico. Initially, I found the idea ridiculous, how could a few prayers and an egg cure years of discomfort? Yet, in a leap of faith, I accepted to be part of the cleansing ritual.

Eloisa recited Christian prayers while rubbing a chicken egg over my skin, searching for my 'Chakras' and making the Sign of the Cross all over my body. Afterward, she broke the egg into a glass of water that contained a few drops of Virgen de Guadalupe's holy water. She explained that the egg had absorbed the "bad eye" energy affecting my well-being. Now I just needed to carry a blessed rosary cross around my neck to make sure the cleansing was final.

Despite my initial skepticism and feeling ridiculous for accepting such a seemingly performative act as an alternative, it worked; my symptoms vanished and I spent the next five years without even suffering from the seasonal flu.

This episode made a profound impact on how I view not only healing rituals but my conception of the forces that organize the universe. How can something that I didn't really believe in, that seemed so performative, have had such a big and corporeal impact on me? Is the archetype of a healing rite so ingrained in me that I didn't have to believe in it to function? Was the intention of healing sufficient to actually improve my wellbeing, and how is it channelled through ritualization?

I thought about it numerous times, but I ended up realizing that why and how it worked was not the focus here. The vital task was to express gratitude and humility for the mysteries and magic that permeate our reality. This project is a continuation of that experience, an act of healing through sound waves and spirit agency.

The Commandment

"Mythology is the physiology of the soul, and dreams are the language in which this physiology speaks." - Carl Jung. 1969. [3.]

In March 2025 I had a lucid dream. An episode seen through a hazy filter. Beings with anthropomorphic shapes performing repetitive actions. They looked mundane and meaningless. Some were climbing invisible ladders, others working at invisible looms. These actions kept in a looped insistence, without any tools or objects, something about them became uncanny. Mysterious. These figures were blue, elongated, marked with golden inscriptions across their bodies. They didn't speak. Their gestures didn't ask to be understood. Still, I couldn't help myself, I kept trying to read into it, to assign meaning, to decode what I was witnessing. It felt like a ritual, but one whose purpose had long been forgotten. Or maybe it never had one to begin with.

In the middle of this silent, looping choreography, while I was still looking for logic, a deep, soft voice cut through the fog: "Meaning is not important. You have to live the mythical life." I still carry that sentence. It hit something in me that I wasn't ready to name. Maybe I'm still not. But it left its echoes resonating inside me. As if I had been asking the wrong question all along, not what does this mean, but how do I live within it?

2. Rivera, V. R. (1944). Limpias mágicas. Revista Hispánica Moderna, 10(3/4), 357–365
3. Jung, C. G. (1969) Collected works of C. G. Jung, volume 9 (part 1): Archetypes and the collective unconscious. Edited by G. Adler and R. F. C. Hull. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Rosa's Universe

Not only in my domestic environment I could recognise a patched spiritual expression, but also in my surroundings. In Northern Portugal, more specifically in the Minho region, I participated in celebrations and communal rituals that weren't purely Catholic, one can recognize in them animistic and polytheistic worldviews and a deep connection with the land ant its governing forces. As Frier (2006) explains, the syncretic practices of Northern Portugal represent a resilient and dynamic cultural system. It is not only a diluted version of official Church dogma, this form of Popular Catholicism practiced across the region operates as a profound cosmological structure in its own right. It utilizes Christian iconography as a strategic vehicle to sustain older, indigenous beliefs centred on land, fertility, and ancestral power. [4.]

For rural Portuguese society, well-being is understood through a holistic lens, integrating the physical, social, and spiritual realms. Within this worldview, the Church simply provides another vocabulary needed to navigate the same elemental forces of magic and energy that have always shaped life in the region.

In Barcelos, where I spent a large part of my teenage years, we can identify this syncretic universe. Here, the intersection of faith and folk life is manifested through communal celebrations structured around the Catholic calendar and, most significantly, in its storied ceramic figurine tradition. Despite significant socio-cultural shifts, this craft has persisted, gradually gaining recognition as a vital artistic expression within the Portuguese cultural sphere.

One of the most important figures in this history is Rosa Ramalho. She was the creator of a unique ceramic universe that mirrored the radical syncretism of the region. Her work encompassed elements of agrarian life, roosters, pigs, chicks, and religious figures like angels, saints or a crossless Jesus Christ, but also demons, personifications of capital sins, and other monsters or animal hybrids.

This universe became fertile ground, not only for her family who carried on her aesthetic, but for other craftspeople like me to develop our own unique cosmologies in clay.

Rosa, like many other ceramicists from the region, often applied small clay whistles to her creations [5.] , a detail I only fully internalized during a visit to the Clay Museum (Museu da Olaria) in Barcelos. This recognition helped cement the idea that I should pursue the sound-making capabilities of clay myself. Historically, ceramicists from the region would travel throughout the country to sell these pieces at festivities and pilgrimages. As these figures were carried to pilgrimages and fairs across the country, their voices became a fundamental component of the Portuguese festive soundscape. It is at this juncture, where clay, sound, and communal celebration converge, that my investigation begins.

4. Frier, D. (2014) 'Syncretisms and popular Catholicisms in Portugal', Portuguese Cultural Studies, 1, pp. 18–24.

5. - Rios, C. (2006) 'Figurado de Barcelos: Desenhos de Barro' , Câmara Municipal de Barcelos.

Rites of a hybrid

My search for syncretic expression led me to the cult of María Lionza, a Venezuelan spiritual tradition defined by its radical syncretism. I was initially drawn to its altars, vibrant, crowded spaces where elements from a vast and diverse universe coexist. Traditional Catholic figures such as Jesus and the Virgin Mary share space with Indigenous caciques, Venezuelan historical heroes, African spirits, doctors, guerrilla fighters, and even notorious criminals. [6.]

Further investigation into the cult revealed that these images are far more than static decorations; they possess a distinct agency within the ritual.[7.] This realization made the performative and ritualistic aspects of the cult inescapable for my own project. To truly understand these figures, I had to engage with the ritual itself.

In the context of María Lionza devotion, the ceramic figurines inhabiting the altars act as representations of spirits summoned for guidance, enlightenment, or healing. Because the cult lacks a central holy book, institutionalized church, or governing authority, it exists in a permanent state of reinvention. This absence of rigid institutional norms allows profound visual creativity to flourish, producing highly personal cosmologies materially expressed through inventive and densely layered altars.

By analyzing specific ritual tools of the cult, the oráculo (floor-drawn oracle), the altar-as-portal, and the phenomenon of spiritual possession, we can see how this tradition constructs a hybrid spiritual expression. The ritual begins with the oráculo: intricate chalk drawings on the ground that delimit and activate sacred space. [8.] In this sense, they function as the "limit" of the ceremony and resonate with Victor Turner's concept of communitas, where structured hierarchies temporarily dissolve into ritual communion. [9.]

As the portal opens, the altar serves as the operative center of the ceremony. Material arrangements often precede and generate the spiritual event itself; the altar functions as a portal through which spirits are invited into the human realm. Even the myth of María Lionza herself remains multiple and unfixed, reflecting the open and adaptive character of the tradition. In contemporary contexts, possession rituals are recorded and circulated on social media platforms, extending ritual space beyond its immediate physical boundaries.

Ultimately, the cult of María Lionza offers a layered and sometimes conflictive system that permits deeply personal interpretations of spirituality while sustaining a shared collective framework.

6. Canals, R. (2017) A goddess in motion: Visual creativity in the cult of María Lionza. 1st edn, vol. 42. New York: Berghahn Books. (page 55.)
7. Canals, R. (2017) A goddess in motion: Visual creativity in the cult of María Lionza. 1st edn, vol. 42. New York: Berghahn Books. (page 92.)
8. Canals, R. (2017) A goddess in motion: Visual creativity in the cult of María Lionza. 1st edn, vol. 42. New York: Berghahn Books. (page 94.)
9. Turner, V. (1969). The ritual process: Structure and anti-structure. Aldine Publishing. (page 96.)

THE PROCESS: CRAFTING THE SPIRITSCAPE

Coming from an illustration background, I began by quickly visualizing how the ceramic objects I was collecting (in image galleries) could form a personal cosmology. Using image-editing (image 1.) software (Photoshop), I explored how these figurines, instruments, and other elements connected to the craft traditions addressed in this project might combine, merge, and attach to one another. This initial stage allowed me to assemble a vocabulary of objects, symbols representing the fragmented yet interconnected aspects of my identity.

I felt particularly drawn to pre-Columbian artifacts. They carry the essence of a culture that is part of who I am, yet one I have always experienced from a distance. Having left Venezuela as a toddler, even today, I relate to it as an outsider, someone observing from the margins. That absence has been filled with a deep admiration and curiosity for the craftscapes of contemporary Amerindian cultures and pre-Hispanic societies.

Zoomorphic and anthropomorphic sound sculptures appear throughout Central and South America. They embody not only elements of nature and indigenous life, but also philosophies of being, systems of belief, and forms of knowledge. As Scher have noted, “The creation and decoration of these works of art (instruments) was often meant to be perceived by nonhuman eyes and ears, reflecting the worldview of the ancient Americas.”

The only way for me to truly engage with these objects was to craft my own versions.

I was not interested in strict narratives or storytelling. I needed to feel them: to bring them into being, (image 2.) sense their weight, and learn how to handle them. How many clay “seeds” does a shaker need to sound? How much breath makes a clay ocarina[10.] sing?

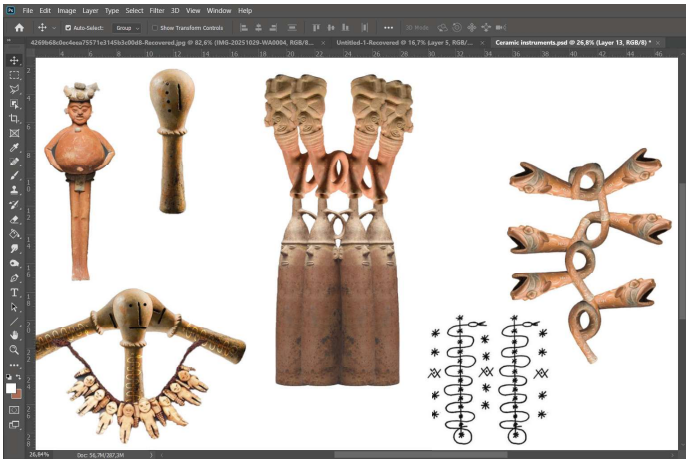


IMAGE 2.
R.Lima 2025.Screenshot from photoshop, editing process.



IMAGE 3.
R.Lima 2025. Process of making antropomorphic and phytomorphic sound objects

10. A wind instrument typically having a globular body with several finger holes and a projecting mouthpiece.

I began with simple, small shakers and one to two-tone aerophones, using them as a starting point to reimagine their forms. I pushed their shapes toward something more sculptural and ambiguous, less concerned with what they were and more with what they could evoke. The process became addictive, a kind of hunt for the sound hidden within the form, a voice waiting to be awakened. The fragility of sound-making proved both hypnotic and obsessive. What keeps me fully engaged is a constant tension between freedom and precision. A millimeter too much or too little can silence a piece or transform it into something warm and resonant.

Alongside the wind instruments, I began working with rattles (maracas), which emerged more quickly and intuitively. Their rounded forms invite anthropomorphization, encouraging the body to relate to them not merely as tools, but as companions. (image 3.) Because these objects require movement to produce sound, they demand conscious, intentional gestures from the player. Sound is no longer just heard, it is felt, embodied, and performed. (image 4.)

As the work developed, the acoustic dimension of these objects became increasingly compelling. This curiosity led me to contact Esteban Valdivia, a music archaeologist from Ecuador, who shared hours of video tutorials, practical exercises, and literary references. I also reached out to the Museum of Pottery of Barcelos to learn more about sound-producing ceramic figurines. These exchanges deepened my understanding of the relationship between ceramics, sound, and ritual practices in indigenous South American cultures as well as Portuguese folk traditions and formed a solid empirical base for the development of my project.



IMAGE 4.
R.Lima 2025. Ceramic rattle and mask.
To listen to the sound od the rattle follow the link :

https://youtube.com/shorts/JnliXUjJCdg



IMAGE 5.

R.Lima 2025. Ocarina incorporated in antrhopomorphic ceramic mask

BETWEEN MATERIAL AND ETHEREAL

The sonic bridge:

"Music is a field, a location, a sacred place an energized poetic domain" - Joel Kroeker (2020) [11].

Sound is a central element in my exploration. Ceramic objects become sounding bodies, vessels not only of form but of resonance, myth, and connection. From Christian choral music and Yoruba drums to Sunni chants and Amazonian sacred flutes, many spiritual traditions recognize sound as a bridge to the divine, ancestors, and collective memory. In this context, music is not merely 'humanly organized sound' but a medium that transcends human boundaries. As noted by Bernd Brabec de Mori and Anthony Seeger (2013)[12] , musical items in rituals are considered agents that can construct or transform perspectives and bodies, bridging the gap between the physical and the spiritual.

In Lowland South American traditions, one of the spiritual building blocks in the Maria Lionza's cult, music is the primary tool for interacting with spirits, animals, and plants. We can recognize in the cult's relationship with drums, chants and other sonic expressions and their role in spiritual possessions.

Ritual specialists use songs to become non-human entities whose agency is required to confront the cause of an illness. Similarly, the Wakuénai (tribes of southernmost Venezuela) use aerophone (wind instrument) performances to 'musicalise' the 'other'.

They become the voice and body of these beings, and their way to gain agency in our reality. Rather than viewing the spirit world as predatory, they domesticate the non-human, creating a harmonious social space where healing communication can occur. (Hill 2013) [13].

This Amerindian worldview offers a profound lens through which to understand how material objects can act as mediators, channeling energies that occupy our physical space. In my own investigation, I have found that my relationship with my ceramic objects becomes increasingly personal through the act of musical creation. Each vessel requires a specific physical engagement to release its full sonic potential. Through this interaction, I sense a distinct personality within each piece and a unique energy that is invoked the moment the object begins to speak.



IMAGE 6.

R.Lima 2025. 20x15x13 Ceramic sounding figurine. Exploring comunication with sound projection.

11. Psychosocial Wednesdays, Joel Kroeker - Jungian music psychotherapy: when psyche sings [video], YouTube, posted 12th August 2020 - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5hk0zliCOPU&t=3033s, 10th December 2025.
12. De Mori, B. B., & Seeger, A. (2013). Introduction: Considering Music, Humans, and Non-humans. Ethnomusicology Forum, 22(3), 269–286
13. Hill, J. D. (2013). Instruments of Power: Musicalising the Other in Lowland South America. Ethnomusicology Forum, 22(3), 323–342

The physics of the “uncanny” voice

Ceramic instruments, particularly those with irregular internal chambers often produce beat frequencies or dissonant intervals. When two slightly different pitches are played together, they create a third sound in the listener’s ear, a pulsing vibration that can feel ghostly or eerie. This is not a musical error; it is a ritual technology. In the context of my ceramic entities, these eerie sounds signal to the brain that we have left the safety of the mundane. The strange sound bypasses the logical mind and speaks directly to the nervous system, creating a state of hyper-awareness.

The eight whistle horn in the shape of a flower is the representation of this sonic phenomenon. The small differences in size, and therefore in its pith, creates a loud and penetrating sound that alerts the listener.

Video of the Uncanny sound instrument (the flower scream) : https://youtube.com/shorts/oyBbaRfmTPQ

Entrainment and the body

Sound enters the body not only through the ears but through skin and even bone conduction. When multiple instruments are played, the phenomenon of “entrainment” occurs, the tendency for rhythmic systems to synchronize. The heart rates and breathing patterns of the community begin to align with the rhythm of the rattles and the drone of the flutes. This physiological synchronization creates a dissolution of the individual ego.

As Anne Koch [14] suggests in her work on healing rituals, the poles of magic and scientific assumptions come closer in these experiences. The “participatory experience of empowerment” allows the individual to access a state of mind where they feel part of a larger, vibrating whole. In this state, the “social mask” becomes impossible to maintain; we are reduced to our vibrating biological essence, creating a space of radical equality and vulnerability.



IMAGE 7.

R.Lima 2025. Assemblage. 80x78x 201 cm
Experimental assemblage of unfired clay body and sonic elements (head with aerophones and ratle figure)

14. Koch, A. (2015). Alternative Healing as Magical Self-Care in Alternative Modernity. Numen, 62(4), 431–459.

Healing tunes: the archetype of home

"(...)by nature music goes beyond what words are able to convey to a level at which music is symbolic or archetypal" - Ward. [15]

The healing proposed in these pages is found not in comfort, but in a shared journey through the "eerie." In a world increasingly defined by automatic social mechanisms and performative identities, the startling but recognizable frequencies of the sounding ceramic entities act as a solvent. They dissolve the social masks, forcing bonding through collective vulnerability. As the soundscape moves from frenetic and chaotic agitation to a deep, resonant hum, reminiscent of the primordial Om, the listener/believer becomes not merely an observer but a fundamental element in a journey that seeks to reorganize the spirit.

As Joel Kroeker (2019) [16.] suggests, musical structure functions as a symbolic map for the human psyche's journey toward wholeness. Central to this is the archetype of "Home," which Kroeker identifies as the point of centrality and resolution within a sonic landscape. He hypothesizes that the movement of sound, whether through the linear and strict tonality of Western traditions or the expansive, cyclical rhythms of West African music, mirrors the monomythic cycle of departure, trial, and return. In Jungian music therapies tap into this resource to help patients in their own process of healing, or individuation. [17.]

In a ritualistic setting, the asynchronous structures found in PHONOTRIENE do not merely provide rhythm; they facilitate a psychic journey where the listener 'travels' in a circular path, eventually returning to a state of resolution. For Kroeker, this musical return is a metaphor for the psychic experience of individuation, where the "gain and loss" experienced during the sonic journey informs the participant's sense of spiritual or emotional rebirth. Therefor, sound acts as a ritualistic vessel that guides the psyche from the familiar (home) through the transformative unknown, and back to a restored center.

Ultimately, the result is that the "washed out" silence following such a performance offers a communal reset. In this void, we find a simpler way of being. One discovers that within the strange, and alongside the stranger, there exists a sanctuary. Through the agency of clay and sound, we are returned to a primordial state and, more importantly, to one another.



IMAGE 8.

R.Lima 2025. Ceramic flute, 35x13x 11cm.
Two chamber intrument with figurine structure.

15. Ward, K. M. (2000) 'Music and the archetypal ground of the psyche', The San Francisco Jung Institute Library Journal, 19(1), p.15

16. Kroeker J. (2019) 'Jungian music psychotherapy. When psyche sings' Routledge, Abingdon.

17. Jung, C. G. (1969) Collected works of C. G. Jung, volume 9 (part 1): Archetypes and the collective unconscious. Edited by G. Adler and R. F. C. Hull. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Ritual essence

"The strategies of ritualization are rooted in the body, they situate the interaction within a symbolically constituted spatial and temporal framework. The circular production of a ritualized body in turn produces ritualized bodily practices."- Valeria Bellomia.[18.]

Looking at the rituals of María Lionza, I was fascinated by the freedom in their expressions. The fluidity and diversity of their rituals. Within this cult, Christian figures coexist with political icons, indigenous heroes, and even representations of Vikings. This observation allowed me to begin tracing my own constellation. Mapping a personal craftscapes and spiritscapes all the elements that inhabit them.

As Gavin Brown (2003)[19.] illustrates, "we can no longer pay homage to ritual's over-confident declaration of form against indeterminacy, as indeterminacy lies at the heart of ritual form". This paradox becomes evident in the act of performance itself. In structuring my own ritual performances, I am often confronted with the tension of the script: how meticulously should the act be designed? There is a persistent worry that only an extremely detailed design can be perceived as ritualistic, yet working with multiple bodies requires a level of openness. The direction of the performance must allow the ritual to breathe, finding its power in the moment where fixed form meets the indeterminate energy of the par ticipants. Interriuality provides a solution to the risk of ritual failure by reusing minor ritual acts or objects from other established rituals (Hornborg. [20.]).

By classifying these elements as tradition, newly invented performances are sensed as traditional rituals rather than just a performance or show.

Evidence of this universal ritual grammar became clear during a short demonstration performed for a diverse group of colleagues. Despite being from vastly different backgrounds, Argentina, Sweden, Estonia, South Korea, and Taiwan, and having distinct religious experiences, the group met the action with a full understanding of the ritualistic character without any prior explanation. This suggests that certain ritualistic actions and aesthetics tap into a universal human understanding, allowing interriuality to overcome the need for cultural-specific scripts. While Hornborg argue that objects only gain ritual agency within the specific social networking of a ritual performance, my experience tells me otherwise. They posit that ritual objects differ from "daily things" because they carry a potential of coming into being only when the performance starts. However, I propose that the ceramic objects crafted in PONOTRIENE carry a ritualistic character before they are ever activated. Their aesthetic communicates their purpose; they possess their own charisma and spiritual energy. This inherent authority is recognized beforehand, independent of the ritualization phase.

The clay entities are not passive actors waiting to be activated; they are already consecrated channels whose form and materiality illustrate their belonging to a ritual realm.



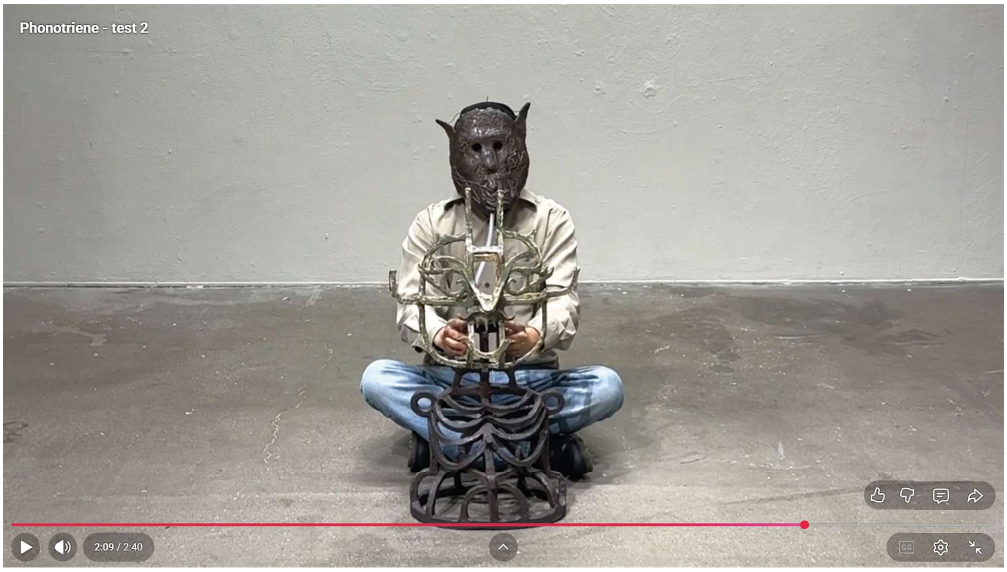


IMAGE 9.
Screenshot from the videos of the development of PHONOTRIENE performance:

- https://youtube.com/shorts/y5J23ryE4g8
- https://youtu.be/B0w6npNdV2Y

18. Bellomia, V. (2021) 'Sound artefacts as containers: The materiality of rhythm in ancient Mesoamerica', Pallas, 115, p.136
19. Brown,G. (2003) 'Theorizing ritual as performance: Explorations of ritual indeterminacy', Journal of Ritual Studies, 17(1), pp. 16.
20. Hornborg, A. (2017). Interriuality as a Means to Perform the Art of Building New Rituals. Journal of Ritual Studies, 31(2), p. 17–27.

Viking repatriation

As a foreigner living in Scandinavia since 2020, incorporating the viking in my personal pantheon has a dual approach. The Viking, functioning as both a historical entity and a potent symbolic archetype, remains a dominant element in the Swedish cultural landscape. I want to reclaim them from Far-right extremists movements that frequently appropriate Viking symbols, Norse mythology, and imagery to promote ideologies of white supremacy, racial purity, and toxic masculinity. A distortion focuses on a fictionalized, all-white Nordic heritage.

In another pay homage to the Venezuelan cult of María Lionza, where Vikings occupy a prestigious position within the spiritual pantheon, with a dedicated spirit court of their own (Corte Vikinga). They are seen as one of the most potent forces in the spirit realm, frequently summoned by mediums (materias) to channel their vitality for the healing of practitioners. These ceremonies often involve intense bodily displays, including ritual self-flagellation. Despite the perceived violence of these scenes, the rituals culminate in a phenomenon where wounds cease bleeding instantaneously, and the practitioners report an absence of physical pain, a testament to the protective power of the Norse spirits.

For decades, this "Nordic energy" has been appropriated by Venezuelan materias for the spiritual benefit of the marialionceros. The ritual recognizes that these ancestors have been "enjoying" the tropical mountains of western Venezuela, but their absence has left a spiritual void in Swedish society. My intention is to summon these spirits to their ancestral homeland, allowing public to reclaim access to their native spiritual powers. Through this symbolic homecoming, the aim is to engage directly with the public's mechanisms of magical thinking, reawakening a connection to a spiritual heritage that has been displaced.

This repatriation is more than a spiritual curiosity; it is a tool for communal healing within a Swedish society that is undergoing its own multicultural transformation. The "mestizo" nature of María Lionza mirrors the fluid delimitations required to navigate a society becoming more diverse. By engaging in this ritual, the practitioner enters a state of "anti-structure" where hierarchies are momentarily dissolved. The ancestor, who has spent years in the company of indigenous caciques and African spirits in the Venezuelan "portales" (altars) returns to Sweden not as a "pure" relic of the past, but as a syncretic, strengthened entity. These Vikings, historically defined by their fearlessness and raw violence, have undergone a spiritual evolution during their tropical exile; they have learned to co-habit with a multitude of spiritual forces.

In this new ritualized form, they can be accessed not just for strength, but as teachers who demonstrate how to navigate and deal with different belief systems and cultures. Ultimately, the strength of the María Lionza's structure lies in its ability to facilitate this "event" of return, proving that by embracing the "intrinsic plurality" of our ancestors, we can find a sense of cohesion that survives even the most radical cultural shifts.



IMAGE 10.

R.Lima 2025. Ceramic Helmet 48x47x50 cm, Representation of a Viking figure through the lense of popular portuguese figurines

Ritual and material mimesis

In PHONOTRIENE I explore how activating the ceramic entities employs material mimesis to reconceptualize ancestral identity as an embodied and living presence rather than a symbolic or historical representation. As Scher (2009) [21] indicates, material objects act as entities that do not signify identity but actively embody it through shared physical, sonic, and spiritual properties. She illustrates how in many Indigenous American ritual traditions, identity was located in the internal, unseen structures of objects, resonant chambers, concealed cavities, and sonic mechanisms, rather than in their external appearance. Ceramic flutes and vessels derived their potency from breath and sound, through which ancestral presence was activated. This logic informs the development of PHONOTRIENE, in which ceramic vessels are conceived as bodily sites or dwellings for Viking ancestral (id)entities.

Engagement with these objects occurs through breath and vibration, allowing identity to be experienced sensorially rather than visually. This is fundamental due to aesthetics of my work not reflecting on Nordic visual vocabulary and appears as exotic and sometime even as undecipherable.



IMAGE 4.

R.Lima 2025. Ceramic mask. 23x30x 9 cm, Ritual mask meant to conceal the identity of the performer/shaman.

21. Scher, S. (2009). Breath of the ancestors. Ceramics Technical, (28), 21–26

CONCLUSION

Standing at the threshold between a Portuguese colonial past and a Venezuelan indigenous heritage, I navigate the complexities of cultural repatriation through a personal lens of hybridity. This research reveals that as a mixed nomadic being, my fragmented identity can become a mediator between realities, geographies, and communities. In a time where divisive discourses plague our reality and corrode our social fabric, I decided it was fundamental to focus on the common denominator that defines us as material and spiritual beings.

Crafting a cosmology where the figure of the Viking takes a central role allowed me to embrace my recent Nordic identity and address issues of belonging. Furthermore, dealing with the archetype of “home” became a focal element in my work, especially in the musical component of the performance. Here, I do not see “home” as a geographical destination, but as an emotional and relational state maintained through ritual and social relationships. By bringing back home Nordic spirits through Venezuelan spiritual mechanisms, the work functions as a symbolic exploration of belonging.

The ceramic figurines produced are not static representations but chimeras, hybrids that serve as ritual tools and embodiments of communal heal ing.

By granting these objects a voice, they transition from passive objects to active mediators capable of challenging the viewer to engage with an immaterial presence. This engagement is an act of kindness, a “reaching out” to a public distant in traditions and social norms, transforming the installation into a universal meeting place where the foreigner can feel seen and connected to the current territory they inhabit, its people, and its timeline.

The sonic ambition of the work, bathing the listener in waves of sound, seeks to move beyond the purely symbolic. In this space, ceramic objects become physical vessels for spirits, providing them a body to enact healing within the material world. PHONOTRIENE thus offers a crafted spiritual medicine designed to return the self to the body and the stranger to the community.

Finally, this journey into the unfamiliar territories of performance and sound has revitalized my practice, opening collaborative paths I previously had not imagined. Reaching out to others, either to deepen my investigation or to develop a performance, awarded me a feeling of safety and support fundamental to stepping into the unknown. The realization that a deeply personal exploration could invite a network of creatives, composers, performers, and designers, to invest in a shared vision has been transformative. By reaching into the depths of my own being, I have found a profound way to connect with others, remaining a humble novice ready to learn in a world of endless mythic and creative possibilities.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- Bellomia, V. (2021) ‘Sound artefacts as containers: The materiality of rhythm in ancient Mesoamerica’, Pallas, 115, pp. 121–145.

- Brown, G. (2003) ‘Theorizing ritual as performance: Explorations of ritual indeterminacy’, Journal of Ritual Studies, 17(1), pp. 3–18.

- Canals, R. (2017) A goddess in motion: Visual creativity in the cult of María Lionza. 1st edn, vol. 42. New York: Berghahn Books.

- de Menezes Bastos, R. J. (2013) ‘Apùap world hearing revisited: Talking with “animals”, “spirits” and other beings, and listening to the apparently inaudible’, Ethnomusicology Forum, 22(3), pp. 287 - 305.

- Frier, D. (2014) ‘Syncretisms and popular Catholicisms in Portugal’, Portuguese Cultural Studies, 1, pp. 18–24.

- Gonçalves, F. (1969) ‘Assobios onomatopaicos dos barristas de Barcelos’, Cadernos de Etnografia, 7 (Segunda Série). Museu de Cerâmica Popular Portuguesa

- Grimes, R. L. (1992) ‘Reinventing ritual’, Soundings: An Interdisciplinary Journal, 75(1), pp. 21–41.

- Hornborg, A. (2017). Interrituality as a Means to Perform the Art of Building New Rituals. Journal of Ritual Studies, 31(2), 17–27.

- Jung, C. G. (1969) Collected works of C. G. Jung, volume 9 (part 1): Archetypes and the collective unconscious. Edited by G. Adler and R. F. C. Hull. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

- Koch, A. (2015). Alternative Healing as Magical Self-Care in Alternative Modernity. Numen, 62(4), 431–459.

- Kroeker J. (2019) ‘Jungian music psychotherapy. When psyche sings’ Routledge, Abingdon

- Rios, C. (2006) ‘Figurado de Barcelos: Desenhos de Barro’ , Câmara Municipal de Barcelos.

- Rivera, V. R. (1944). Limpias mágicas. Revista Hispánica Moderna, 10(3/4), 357–365

- Scher, S. (2009). Breath of the ancestors. Ceramics Technical, (28), 21–26

- Turner, V. (1969). The ritual process: Structure and anti-structure. Aldine Publishing.

- Ward, K. M. (2000) ‘Music and the archetypal ground of the psyche’, The San Francisco Jung Institute Library Journal, 19(1), pp. 11–35.

IMAGE REFERENCES

IMAGE 1. R.Lima, 2025. 41x45x17 cm.
Ceramic sounding mask. Glazed Stoneware - object from the PHONOTRIENE series

IMAGE 2.
R.Lima 2025.Screenshot from photoshop, editing process

IMAGE 3.
R.Lima 2025. Process of making antropomorphic and phytomorphic sound objects.

IMAGE 4.
R.Lima 2025. Ceramic rattle and mask.

IMAGE 5.
R.Lima 2025. Ocarina incorporated in antrhopomorphic ceramic mask

IMAGE 6.
R.Lima 2025. 20x15x13 Ceramic sounding figurine. Exploring comunication with sound projection.

IMAGE 7.
R.Lima 2025. Ceramic mask. 80x78x 201 cm
Experimental assemblage of unfired clay body and sonic elements (head with aerophones and ratle figure)

IMAGE 8.
R.Lima 2025. Ceramic flute, 35x13x 11cm. Two chamber intrument with figurine structure.

IMAGE 9.
Screenshot from the videos of the development of PHONOTRIENE performance:

- https://youtube.com/shorts/y5J23ryE4g8

- https://youtu.be/B0w6npNdV2Y

IMAGE.10
R.Lima 2025. Ceramic Helmet 48x47x50 cm, Representation of a Viking figure through the lense of popular portuguese figurines

IMAGE 11.
R.Lima 2025. Ceramic mask. 23x30x 9 cm, Ritual mask meant to conceal the identity of the performer/ shaman.

APENDIX

From the beginning of this degree project, the intent was always for the sound objects to be performed live. However, as the exhibition approached, I found myself faced with uncomfortable decisions. Despite having designed the instruments and the blueprint of the ritual, I experienced a profound resistance to occupying the role of the performer. I initially distanced myself from this, operating under the assumption that a musician would be better suited to activate the work.

My collaboration with the creative agency SDV Works, a performing arts label based in Stockholm, proved vital in navigating this impasse. Rather than allowing me to outsource the performance, they challenged my reluctance, forcing me to confront why I felt my own body was an unsuitable vehicle for the work I had created. This was the most challenging stage of the project: moving from the position of the maker to the active subject of the performative part of the work.

My tendency toward perfectionism created a friction between the objects and the performance. I had spent months perfecting the sonic qualities and the formal aesthetics of the pieces, the four-day rehearsal period right before the examination felt extremely short and last-minute effort. I struggled with the reality that, while the ceramic objects had been meticulously crafted, they were lacking experimentation to account for the physical constraints of a performance. I was concerned that the objects and the performance will not become a singular, intertwined system.

This concern gradually faded as rehearsals began. Slowly, the performance took shape before my eyes, developed intuitively and with wonderful support from the team. The collaborators also felt a degree of hesitation initially, as they were mindful not to "desecrate" the work. It became my responsibility to invite them in, ensuring they felt empowered to contribute to the piece. This process of learning each other's creative methods and sharing a vision was a deeply bonding experience and one that I intend to foster in my future practice.

The success of the performance, and the way I was able to command the audience's attention, validated my original vision and the methodology used to develop the work. It confirmed that the pieces were never intended to be activated by a third party; they required the intentional presence of the maker to complete the circuit between sound, ritual, and ceramic form.

Looking forward, this project has redefined my methodology and shifted the boundaries of my practice. Looking forward, I intend to integrate the development of the performance with the creation of the ceramic pieces and reach out to more artist that can help me develop the sonic and movement aspect of the work. This project has been a leap into creative territories I did not imagine possible at the start of this education. By embracing my role as both maker and performer, I have developed a more fluid, integrated practice. I leave this project with a refreshed understanding of the maker's role: the body not just an operator of the instrument, but a foundational component of the artwork itself.